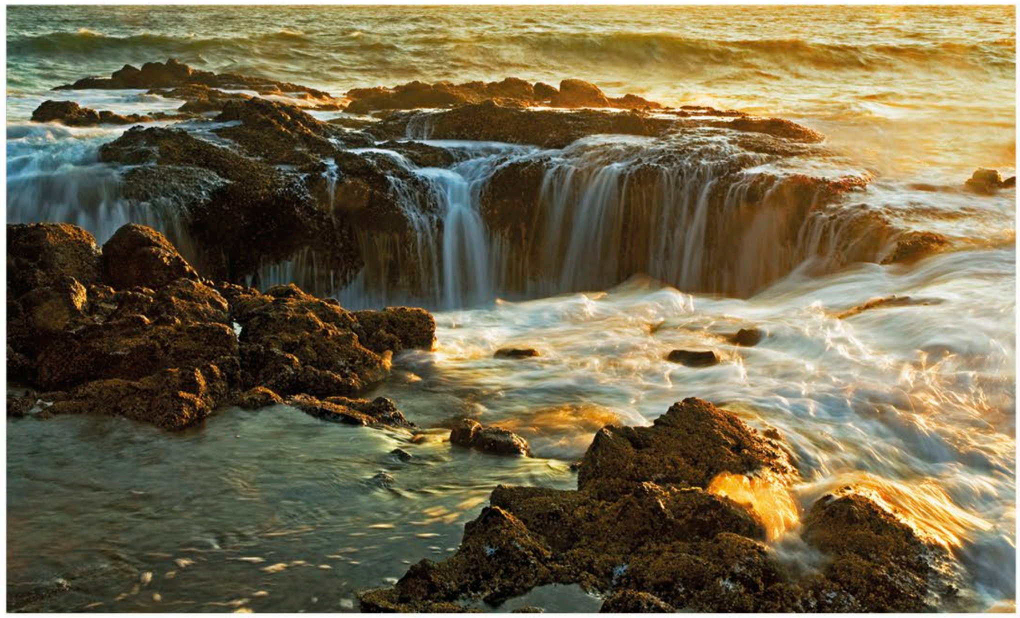
Thor’s Well

A gaping hole in a rocky stretch of Oregon’s coastline that acts like a giant drainpipe

Situated on an area of coast called Cape Perpetua, Thor’s Well is circular in shape, about 20 ft (6 m) deep, and has a hole at the bottom that connects with the open sea. As the waves crash in at high tide, the well fills up, overflows, and spouts seawater into the air. The water is then sucked back for several seconds, making it appear as if the sea is being drained.

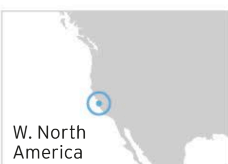
Churning chasm

Thor’s Well churns most spectacularly around the time of high tide. The stirring action depends on the height of the high tide and the direction and size of the waves. The wind can also be a factor. During storms, water can burst out of the well extremely violently, making it too dangerous to approach closely.



△ NATURAL DRAIN
Every 10 seconds or so, during high tide, it seems as if the ocean is being drained away down a bottomless hole. This can be a dramatic sight.

A large number of **mussels** gamely **cling on** to the well’s **internal walls** as the water churns



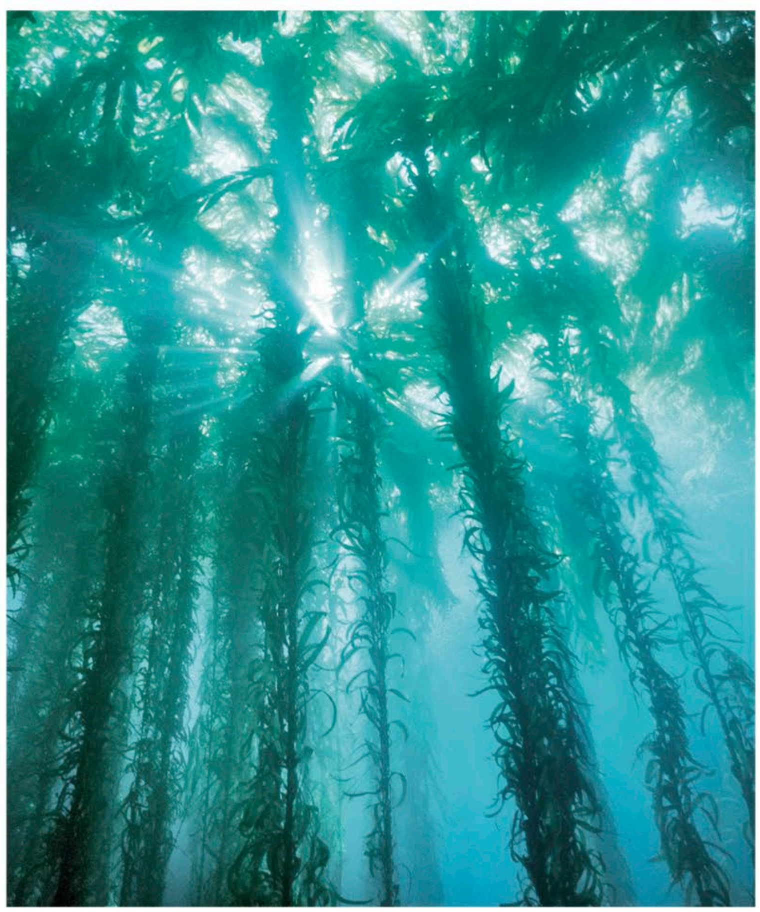
Monterey Bay

A diverse ecosystem, with an underwater canyon and kelp forests on the sea bottom

Monterey Bay occupies a large stretch of the coast of central California. Underwater is a thick forest of kelp and the shore end of one of the world’s longest undersea canyons, which runs for 60 miles (100 km) to the southwest. Around the bay are some pristine beaches and jewel-like tide pools.

Marine sanctuary

Offshore, the Monterey Bay National Marine Sanctuary covers a much larger area of around 6,100 square miles (15,700 square km). It is home to a fantastic diversity of sea life, including more than 30 species of mammals, over 300 species of fish, and nearly 100 bird species.



◁ ALGAL FOREST
Several species of kelp, a form of seaweed, grow in the bay’s nutrient-rich waters. Kelp can grow up to 20 in (50 cm) a day, with some specimens becoming as tall as trees.